

DESTROYERS AND ESCORTS

By the outbreak of World War I, destroyers had grown in size, and now displaced 1,000 tons or more. They were still built for speed – well over 30 knots was normal – and mounted 4-inch guns or larger, as well as torpedoes. Their primary function during conflict was to defend the battle fleet against attack from similar ships or torpedo-boats, although they were also used to hunt submarines. The battle fleet became an obsolete concept by 1939, but destroyers survived. Enlarged still further, up-gunned, and armed with an array of depth-charges, they were employed – along with a new generation of smaller escorts – to guard convoys of merchant ships against attack from submarines and aircraft.

► SMS G37 (1914)
Commissioned 1915
Origin Germany
Displacement 1,050 tons
Length 79.5m (260ft)
Top speed 34.5 knots

Krupp-Germaniawerft's G37-class followed an experimental design. They had a shorter forecastle in an attempt to improve their rough-weather performance. G37 was mined in November 1917, in the North Sea.

▼ HMS AVON VALE
Commissioned 1941 Origin UK
Displacement 1,625 tons
Length 85.3m (280ft)
Top speed 27 knots

Avon Vale was the first of the second group of Hunt-class destroyer-escorts built in the early years of World War II. This multirole ship was designed to protect merchant convoys from attack from both submarines and aircraft.



Twin propellers driven by steam turbines



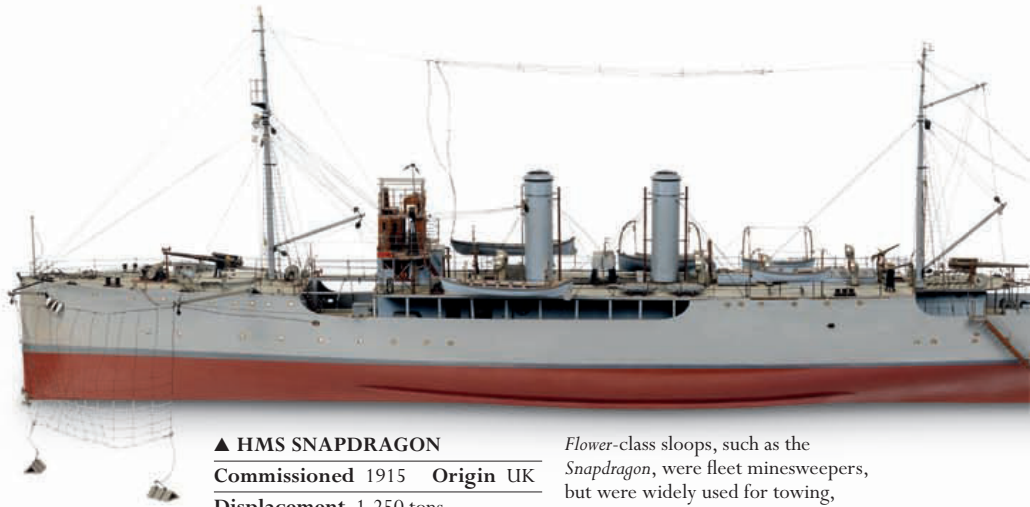
Depth charges

Light anti-aircraft gun

4in gun

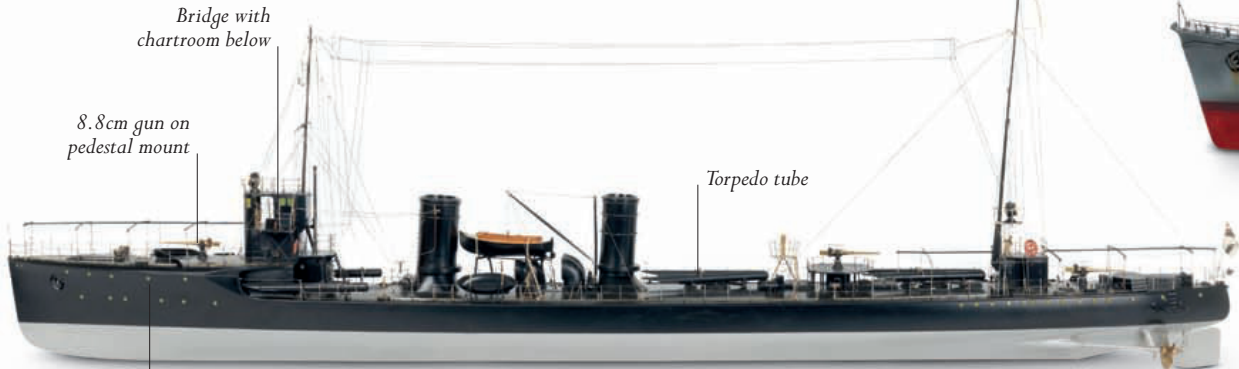
▼ HMS ACANTHUS
Commissioned 1940 Origin UK
Displacement 1,245 tons
Length 62.5m (205ft)
Top speed 16.5 knots

Corvettes such as HMS Acanthus were the smallest purpose-built warships used for convoy escort duties during World War II. Their design was based on that of commercial whale-catchers, and they were powered by piston engines, rather than turbines.



▲ HMS SNAPDRAGON
Commissioned 1915 Origin UK
Displacement 1,250 tons
Length 81.7m (268ft)
Top speed 16 knots

Flower-class sloops, such as the Snapdragon, were fleet minesweepers, but were widely used for towing, reprovisioning, and crew transfers. They were built in large numbers by non-specialist yards.



Bridge with chartroom below

8.8cm gun on pedestal mount

Torpedo tube

Smaller forecastle for stability in bad weather